

Put the Team Before Yourself: 4-Minute Mile Pacesetters, Featuring Virginia Means

Virginia Means, Chief People Officer, United Distributors, Inc.

Coach Summitt said, “How do you create a successful team? How do you convince a group of highly talented individual performers to set aside their personal feelings, ambitions, and agendas in favor of a unified effort? It’s no easy matter. As a coach, I have to be at my most inventive and articulate when I talk about teamwork. But basketball happens to be a wonderful tool with which to teach it.”

Pat Summitt held an unflinching belief that her teams would always achieve more than any one individual superstar player. Pat also knew that it goes against human nature to put the team before yourself. Like all skills, you have to work at it.

You may have heard of Roger Bannister. Roger was the first person to break the four-minute mile. So, what does a guy who ran a record breaking four-minute mile have to do with teamwork? On that cold day at Iffley Road Track in 1954 Roger Bannister had a plan. You see, when he walked up to that starting line, there were two other guys on his team, Chris Brasher and Chris Chataway. When the gun sounded, Brasher rushed into the lead, followed by Bannister and Chataway. And it stayed that way for half a mile. Bannister then gave the signal and Brasher fell back. Chataway went into the lead with Bannister right behind. It stayed that way until the final 200 yards of the race. When Bannister kicked it into top gear, passing Chataway and crossing the finish line in record time, 3 minutes and 59 and four tenths seconds.

So, what role did Chris Brasher and Chris Chataway play? They were Bannister’s pacesetters. Bannister knew that his best chance to make history, especially on a day that had horrible conditions, was to have the help of others. His teammates, Chris Brasher and Chris Chataway, took on a specific role and quite frankly, humbled themselves for the greater good of the outcome.

Working together as a team, even when you may not be the one to get the glory, can yield phenomenal results. Pat Summitt spent her career helping great athletes and role players work together to achieve greatness. In any team and in any enterprise, sometimes someone is the hero and sometimes someone is the pacesetter. But both are needed to achieve greatness.